My spouse, Vandana, continues to be my support and mainstay as I transition from being a former civil servant to a writer and student of contemporary China. I think she knows how much of a contribution she has made towards assisting me in ensuring that this manuscript sees the light of day.

In this century, India's relationship with China will become its most important diplomatic relationship. I wrote this book because I felt that the generations to come might benefit by learning about China from those who have dealt with the subject. I hope that this book will encourage more Indians to take up the study of China. I dedicate this book to the officers of the Indian Foreign Service in the hope that the insights contained herein may prove helpful to them in their future dealings with the Chinese.